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Dubai Police

DUBAI POLICE BRING UAE FLAG CELEBRATION TO COMMUNITIES

■ Dubai Police took national celebrations beyond public spaces and into neighbourhoods, joining residents across the emirate in marking the 'Proud of UAE' campaign with a strong display of unity and patriotism. Led by the General Department of Community Happiness, the campaign saw residential areas transformed into festive settings. Dubai Police teams distributed UAE flags to residents and engaged with families in an atmosphere of celebration.

TRUMP SAYS DEAL NEAR AS US SENDS MESSAGE TO IRAN

Pakistan steps up mediation but Tehran holds firm

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N.R.
Senior Associate Editor

US President Donald Trump voiced fresh optimism that a deal with Iran to end the war could be within reach, even as a fragile two-week ceasefire holds and tensions persist over a naval blockade and stalled negotiations.

Trump said the conflict was "very close to over" and suggested a new round of direct US-Iran talks could begin soon, raising hopes of a diplomatic breakthrough after weeks of escalating violence. "I think we're very close," Trump said, adding that renewed negotiations could be "amazing."

However, Tehran struck a cautious tone. Iranian foreign ministry spokesman Esmail Baqaei said no date had been set for fresh talks, although indirect contacts were continuing through Pakistan following a first round of negotiations in Islamabad that failed to produce a breakthrough. Pakistan has stepped up mediation, with Chief of Defence Forces Field Marshal Asim Munir leading a high-level delegation to Tehran with a message from Washington and pushing to revive talks before the truce expires.

Fresh message

Iranian state media said the high-level Pakistani delegation was carrying a fresh message from Washington and was expected to discuss preparations for a second round of talks.

"Since Sunday... several messages have been exchanged through Pakistan," Baqaei said, signalling that backchannel diplomacy remains active. Paki-

TEHRAN THREATENS TO BLOCK RED SEA TRADE

Iran's military warned yesterday it could shut down trade routes across the Red Sea and Gulf waters if the United States does not lift its naval blockade on Iranian ports.

Washington said the blockade has halted Iran's maritime trade, with US Central Command (CENTCOM) claiming no vessels have made it past American forces and that nine ships were turned back in the first 48 hours. However, maritime tracking data paints a less clear picture. Data from Kpler indicated that at least three ships departing Iranian ports crossed the Strait of Hormuz after the blockade began, though some later turned back.

Iran's Tasnim news agency also reported continued shipping activity from southern ports. Ali Abdollahi, head of Iran's military central command centre, warned that failure to lift the blockade would be a "prelude" to violating the two-week ceasefire. He said Iran would block all exports and imports across the Gulf, the Sea of Oman and the Red Sea if the pressure continues.

—S. N. R.

stan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, meanwhile, arrived in Saudi Arabia before a possible second round of US-Iran peace talks. Sharif will also visit Qatar and Turkey on his trip, which comes after Washington and Tehran held their highest-level talks in decades in Islamabad last weekend.

The Pakistani leader will discuss the "regional situation" with Crown Prince Mohammed Bin Salman, his office said.

The earlier US-Iran talks, which lasted around 21 hours, marked the highest-level contact between the two sides in decades. The US delegation was led by Vice President JD Vance, while Iran's team was headed by parliament speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf.

Despite the engagement, key differences remain unresolved. Trump has criticised Iran for refusing to reopen the Strait of Hormuz and for holding firm on its nuclear programme.

Reports suggest Washington is seeking a long-term suspension of Iran's uranium enrich-

ment, while Tehran has proposed a shorter pause — an offer US officials have rejected.

Baqaei dismissed some US demands as "unreasonable and unrealistic," while reiterating Iran's right to pursue peaceful nuclear energy. He added that the level of enrichment remains negotiable, but insisted Iran would not accept terms imposed under pressure. Meanwhile, a senior US official said Washington had not formally agreed to extend the ceasefire beyond its current timeline, even as engagement with Iran continues.

Global divisions over the war are also sharpening. British Prime Minister Keir Starmer has refused to join the conflict despite pressure from Washington, insisting the UK "will not be dragged into this war" and that it is not in Britain's national interest. Trump, in turn, criticised London's stance and warned that a favourable US-UK trade deal "can always be changed," highlighting growing strains between the allies.

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Mansour discusses de-escalation with Iran parliament speaker

UAE elected to WFP board amid rising global food security risks

ABU DHABI

BY ABDULLA RASHEED
Abu Dhabi Editor

Sheikh Mansour Bin Zayed Al Nahyan, Vice-President, Deputy Prime Minister and Chairman of the Presidential Court, held a phone call with Mohammad Baqer Ghalibaf, Speaker of the Parliament of Iran, during which they discussed regional developments and ways to de-escalate tensions in the region.

This is the first high-level call since the start of the US-Israel-Iran war.

Meanwhile, the UAE has been elected to the Executive Board of the World Food Programme (WFP) for the 2026–2028 term, at a time of unprecedented global food security challenges and mounting risks linked to the near-total disruption of traffic through the Strait of Hormuz — developments that could push tens of millions into acute hunger. The UAE's election underscores its pivotal role within the global humanitarian ecosystem. It marks a shift from a leading donor to a strategic partner, reflecting its vision of a world free from hunger.

It also reinforces its commitment to linking humanitarian response with sustainable development and building more resilient food systems.

Shaping strategic direction

Ambassador Mohamed Abushahab, UAE Permanent Representative to the United Nations, stated: "Our membership on this Board strengthens the UAE's role in shaping the strategic direction of the World Food Programme. We will work to place innovation, logistical efficiency, and resilient food systems at the core of the international response — today and in the future."

IN-PERSON CLASSES FROM APRIL 20

UAE's Ministry of Education has announced the resumption of in-person education for all children and students, as well as educational and administrative staff, in nurseries, kindergartens, public and private schools and universities, starting Monday, April 20, 2026.

US lifts advisory

Meanwhile, the United States Embassy in the UAE has lifted its 'shelter-in-place' advisory for its employees following the cessation of recent missile and drone attacks.

In an update, the embassy said staff may resume normal movement but advised that they should be ready to seek immediate shelter indoors if any new aerial threat emerges. The same precaution applies to all US citizens in the country.

Despite the easing of restrictions, the US continues to maintain its travel advisory for the UAE at Level 3, urging citizens to reconsider travel.

— Nathaniel Lacsina,
Senior Web Editor

The UAE's election comes at a critical juncture, as oil tanker traffic through the Strait of Hormuz has declined by more than 90 per cent since February 28, amid escalating Iranian attacks on regional states and increasing threats to maritime security in this vital waterway.

The United Nations has warned that continued disruption could drive an additional 45 million people into acute hunger, while a further 4 million people in the Arab world risk falling into poverty.

— with inputs from WAM

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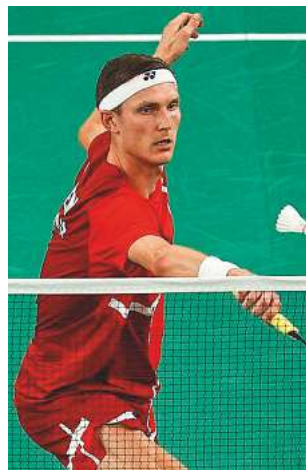
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Why Dubai's iconic Burj Al Arab is getting a facelift after 25 years

Dubai's sail-shaped landmark hotel will be restored in phases

DUBAI

BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

Dubai's most recognisable hotel, Jumeirah Burj Al Arab, is set to undergo its first major restoration programme since opening in 1999.

The hotel, owned by Jumeirah Group — a subsidiary of Dubai Holding, said the renovation is aimed at preserving one of the emirate's most famous symbols for future generations.

Jumeirah announced on Tuesday that the dhow sail-shaped hotel — long regarded as an emblem of Dubai's global luxury tourism ambitions — will begin a phased restoration expected to last around 18 months. The hotel group confirmed it will remain closed during that time.

The work will focus on carefully conserving and enhancing the property's distinctive interiors, while maintaining uninterrupted standards of luxury hospitality, the hotel group said in a statement.

The project will be led by acclaimed French



interior architect Tristan Auer, chosen after what Jumeirah described as a rigorous selection process. Auer is known internationally for restoring celebrated heritage properties including Hôtel de Crillon in Paris.

Thomas B. Meier, CEO of Jumeirah, said the restoration is about more than upgrading a hotel building. "Jumeirah Burj Al Arab is far more than an architectural landmark; it is a symbol of ambition, craftsmanship and enduring excellence," he said.

SEE ALSO P10